people: If there was a real people's movement to get me to run, then I said I'd do it, but I was going to wait and see.

Paul Laxalt asked if he could put together the nucleus of a campaign organization for 1980 in case I decided to run. I told him I wouldn't object, but it wasn't a commitment. He accepted my terms and tirelessly went to work organizing for a campaign that might never take place.

As this was going on, we picked up the threads of our life in Southern California and enjoyed it very much. After the enforced separation of the campaign, we got to see the children more often. Nancy, always the nest builder, never ceased fixing up and redecorating our house in Pacific Palisades and she kept busy with the Foster Grandparents Program. And we had more time than ever for the ranch and more time for travel. On a trip to England, I bumped into Justin Dart, one of the Californians who'd been in my Kitchen Cabinet, and he said he wanted me to meet a friend of his who had recently been elected the first woman to head the British Conservative Party.

I'd planned on spending only a few minutes with Margaret Thatcher but we ended up talking for almost two hours. I liked her immediately—she was warm, feminine, gracious, and intelligent—and it was evident from our first words that we were soul mates when it came to reducing government and expanding economic freedom. At a reception that evening, an Englishman who had heard about our meeting asked me, "What do you think of our Mrs. Thatcher?"

I said I'd been deeply impressed. "I think she'd make a magnificent prime minister."

He looked at me out of the corners of his eyes with a kind of mocking disdain that seemed to suggest the idea was unthinkable: "My dear fellow, a *woman* prime minister?"

"England once had a queen named Victoria who did rather well," I said.

"By jove," he said, "I'd forgotten all about that."